ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Should We Trust Our Dreams?

Derech Hashem 3:1:6

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 1, paragraph 6 (end of the chapter on dreams), and the opening of Chapter 2, paragraph 1
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 1 November 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: the soul and what happens in sleep

The Rabbi opened by summarising the chapter so far. Every person has an animal nefesh, and a human being also has a Neshamah. The Neshamah has five parts. Its lowest part, also called the nefesh, is tied to the animal nefesh, which in turn is tied to the blood. Because the soul has these parts, a person can sometimes receive extra levels, as on Shabbat, and can sometimes have intuition through them.

The main time this happens is in sleep. The day is the time of work and the night the time of rest. When we sleep, four fifths of the soul leaves us (which is why we wash our hands in the morning) and has a kind of spiritual freedom. What it brings back depends on whom it was "in conversation with". With good malakhim, it returns with true information, sometimes a hint of the future. With shedim, the Malakhei Habbalah, it returns with falsehood.

So a dream can be false for two reasons: the soul was in contact with a negative force, or the dream is simply the imagination replaying the thoughts of the day.

"There is no dream without some nonsense"

The last paragraph of the chapter sums it up. A dream is either pure imagination, with no validity, or a mirror of what the soul has been doing: true if it came through a malakh, false if it came through a shed. And even the best dream is mixed with imagination. Hazal say that every dream contains something false.

The Rabbi asked for the source in Sefer Bereshit. The answer is Yosef's dream of the sun, the moon and the eleven stars. The stars were his brothers and the sun his father, but the moon, his mother, could not bow to him, since Rahel had already died. From this the Hakhamim learned that no dream is free of falsehood. (A participant asked whether Yaakov ever bowed; the Rabbi said he did, when the family came down to Egypt.)

So are dreams important or not? On one hand the pasuk says dreams "speak falsehood". On the other, the Gemara in Berakhot devotes about three pages to interpreting them. The

answer is that it depends on where the dream came from, and even a holy dream carries some imagination.

Great sleepers and the "sleep of a horse"

Rabbi Hayim Vital wrote of his teacher, the Arizal, that he attained in his sleep what a person needs seventy years to attain awake, because with the right connections the soul is taken upwards.

The halacha is that one should not sleep by day more than "the sleep of a horse", sixty breaths. Some say that is two or three minutes. Others say two or three hours, citing the Arizal's Shabbat afternoon sleep. To that some answer that Shabbat is different, and others that the Arizal was different, since his sleep was an exploration of the upper worlds.

A participant noted that sleep is one sixtieth of death and a dream one sixtieth of prophecy. The Rabbi said a prophetic dream is prophecy itself, which has its own chapter later. One sixtieth always means something negligible, as with meat and milk: you cannot build on it.

Answers from heaven, and acting on dreams

He showed the group *Sheelot uTeshuvot min HaShamayim*, "Responsa from Heaven", by one of the Rishonim, Rabbenu Yaakov of Marvege. He would pose a question before sleeping and receive the answer in a dream. One question was whether women may say the berakhah on the lulav; he was told they may. Hakham Ovadiah brings this and says we cannot rely on such things, and rules that women do not say the berakhah.

The Gemara tells of a man whose late father appeared in a dream and said the inheritance belonged to the poor. He was told he could keep it. If the father had truly set it aside as sedakah it would not be his, but a dream always has an element of imagination, and this could be the false part. (A participant told a story of a trader in Shanghai whose father appeared in dreams asking him to build a shul, which later served the refugee yeshivah students there.)

Fasting on Shabbat is forbidden apart from Yom Kippur, with one exception in the sources: a fast for a bad dream. Today the halacha is that we do not, because we assume the dream is a waste of time. And the saying that "a dream follows its interpretation" fits the same idea: since part of every dream is imagination, the way it is interpreted shapes that part.

His conclusion: "If it's a good dream, take it seriously. If it's a bad dream, ignore it." Dreams are not to be taken lightly, but nor should we be too concerned with them.

Chapter 2: going up a level

The Rabbi then mapped the rest of Part 3. Chapter 2 is about the use of God's names and about kishuf (witchcraft); chapter 3 about prophecy; chapter 4 about more details of prophecy; chapter 5 about the prophecy of Moshe Rabbenu. "We're working up higher levels of divine knowledge." Dreams are the lowest level; now we will see how certain righteous people did things above nature, and also how black magic works.

Paragraph 1 is revision of Part 1. Everything physical has a counterpart above. The true essence of anything lies in its spiritual root, and what we see in the physical world is only its branch. Everything comes down in an organised chain, each level passing to the next, until it reaches

the physical. That ordered chain is why nature works and does not change. The question for next time: if that is how nature is built, how could a person get around it, and why is it so dangerous to try?

Summary

- Dreams can be false because of contact with negative forces or because they simply replay the day's thoughts.
- Even a true dream contains falsehood, as Hazal learned from Yosef's dream of the sun and moon.
- Halacha does not rely on dreams: not to give away an inheritance, not to decide a ruling, not to fast on Shabbat today.
- The balance: take a good dream seriously and ignore a bad one.
- Chapter 2 begins by recalling that all of nature descends in an ordered chain from its spiritual root.

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